

FIP: What Every Cat Owner Should Know

*Receiving this guide does **not** mean your adopted cat has FIP or is expected to develop it. **Early recognition saves lives**, and this guide is simply intended to help you recognize FIP should it ever become a concern.*

Why Are We Giving You This Information?

Feline Infectious Peritonitis (FIP) has become much more common in recent years, particularly in kittens and young cats. Because almost all cats are exposed to feline coronavirus (FCoV) at some point in their lives, **any cat has the potential to develop FIP if that virus mutates—but the vast majority never will.**

We're providing this guide because modern FIP treatment has changed dramatically over the past few years. Today, FIP is highly treatable when recognized early, but diagnosis can still be confusing and recommendations may vary. Our goal is to help you recognize the warning signs, avoid unnecessary delays, and know that you have experienced people to turn to if questions ever arise.

FAQ

What is FIP?

Feline Infectious Peritonitis (FIP) is a disease that occurs when the common feline coronavirus (FCoV) mutates inside a cat's body. While feline coronavirus is widespread, **most cats exposed to it will never develop FIP.**

Is FIP the same as FeLV or FIV?

No. FIP is completely different and is **not related** to FeLV or FIV. Every cat adopted through Rescued Treasures Pet Adoptions is tested for FeLV and FIV prior to adoption, and all cats are negative before going to their new homes.

Is FIP contagious?

No. While feline coronavirus is common and spreads between cats, **the mutated virus that causes FIP cannot spread from one cat to another.**

If most cats are exposed to feline coronavirus, does that mean they'll get FIP?

No. Exposure to feline coronavirus is very common, especially in kittens and cats that have lived with other cats. **The vast majority of cats exposed to FCoV will never develop FIP.** FIP occurs only if the virus mutates inside an individual cat—a rare event that cannot currently be predicted. Simply being exposed does **not** mean a cat has FIP or is likely to develop it.

Our goal isn't to make you worry—it's to help you recognize FIP early and know where to turn if it ever becomes a concern.

Is FIP still a death sentence?

No. Thanks to modern antiviral medications, FIP is now highly treatable. When recognized and treated early, the success rate is excellent.

Symptoms to Watch For

FIP can look like many other illnesses. One symptom alone usually isn't concerning, but several occurring together should raise suspicion—especially in kittens and young cats.

- Persistent fever that doesn't improve with antibiotics
- Loss of appetite
- Lethargy or hiding
- Weight loss
- Swollen abdomen or difficulty breathing due to fluid buildup
- Eye inflammation or vision changes
- Neurologic signs such as wobbliness, tremors, or seizures
- Sudden changes in behavior or personality

These symptoms do not automatically mean your cat has FIP, but they do warrant prompt veterinary evaluation.

Diagnosis: There Is No Single Test

There is **no single test** that can confirm or rule out FIP. Diagnosis is based on your cat's symptoms, physical examination, CBC, chemistry panel (especially globulin levels and the albumin/globulin ratio), age, medical history, and response to treatment.

Always ask your veterinarian for a printed or digital copy of your cat's bloodwork.

Our Experience

Over the past several years, Rescued Treasures Pet Adoptions has successfully treated dozens of cats with FIP using modern antiviral medications. Because FIP diagnosis and treatment have changed so rapidly, some veterinarians have limited experience with the disease and may recommend extensive testing or treatment trials before considering FIP. This can delay antiviral treatment and lead to significant unnecessary expense. If FIP is ever suspected, we're happy to review bloodwork, discuss concerns, and help you find the most efficient path forward while working alongside your veterinarian.

There Is Hope

Until recently, FIP was considered almost always fatal. Today, thanks to modern antiviral medications, it has become one of the most treatable serious diseases in cats. Many cats begin showing noticeable improvement within just a few days of starting treatment, and when recognized early, the chances of a full recovery are excellent.

Questions? We're Here to Help.

If your veterinarian mentions FIP—or you simply wonder if it could be FIP—we're happy to review bloodwork, discuss symptoms, and share our experience navigating diagnosis and treatment.

rescuedtreasurescats@gmail.com